in the West realised that an undefined status for Kosovo presented a greater risk for itself and the region than an independent Kosovo did for the stability of Serbia, despite being a truly difficult loss. (A loss that could have probably been prevented even after the fall of Milošević, had the assassination of Prime Minister Djindjić in 2003 not set the clocks back.) On the other hand, it is true that Serbia did not really want Kosovo, at least not in its entirety – it only wanted the territory, together with its Serbs and the Serbian heritage, but not its ethnic Albanians. It is now up to young Kosovo to figure out how the two ethnic communities can live together. Poverty, social conservatism, corruption, large-scale emigration and links to organised crime continue to be serious issues not only for Kosovo itself but also for other European countries such as Switzerland, France and Slovenia where (Kosovo) Albanians live in considerable numbers. (The UK has its own issue with the emigrants from Albania proper.) So far it appears that Kosovo has not yet used its potential compared with the rest of the ethnic Albanian population of the region.

Kosovo is not the only nation to have fled Serbia. Even the Serbians' Montenegrin half-brothers went their own way in 2006, fed up with the eternal struggle in Serbia between liberal pro-Europeanism and the various incarnations of post-Milošević nationalism, combined with flirting with Russia, which an important part of the electorate finds attractive. As of 2022 a similar battle within Montenegro is not yet decided.

Another neighbour of Kosovo, once simply Macedonia, now North Macedonia, is also a vulnerable part of the Balkans. The wounds of the relatively short inter-ethnic conflict between Albanians and Macedonians in 2001 have been largely healed and the saga with Greece over the use of the name 'Macedonia' resolved. Greece had felt that its poor and weak western neighbour had stolen the name. The Macedonians had been stubborn and had not wanted to give it up, even if EU and NATO membership were at stake. (Greece had effectively blocked the entry of the then former Yugoslav Republic of Macedonia into NATO at the organisation's summit in Bucharest in April 2008.) Indeed, they had not been helpful at all: to make a point they had named the country's main airport after Alexander the Great and had furbished the Prime Minister's office in Skopje with locally excavated artefacts from Greek times rather than those of early Slavic Christianity in the area, which would be more characteristically